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Virginia Board of Education, Business Meeting, Thursday, October 29, 2026

Date	Thursday, October 29, 2026
Place	Virginia Board of Education (Virginia Department of Education), Richmond, Virginia
Length	2h 14m (video)

- Official meeting video (VDOE, YouTube): https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=COnQGrgBtsw
- Board of Education meetings, agendas and minutes (VDOE): https://www.doe.virginia.gov/state-board-data-funding/virginia-board-of-education

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[00:09:38] Good morning. It is, excuse me, it is 9am and I will call this meeting to order. As is customary for this board, we will begin with a moment of silence, followed by the Pledge of Allegiance.

[00:09:53] I will just begin with brief remarks.

[00:10:34] The board had a very productive working session yesterday, and we are incredibly appreciative of Secretary Smith for joining us, sharing the priorities. And so I do encourage folks to look at our video feed of that.

[00:10:52] I think it outlines a clear vision for education in the state of Virginia. And so, again, I want to extend our thank you to the Secretary. With that, I'll ask, is there a motion to approve the agenda as presented? So moved.

[00:11:09] Ms. McPherson? Mr. Robinson? Aye. Dr. Bridges? Aye. Mrs. Kilgore? Aye. And Chair Rhoades, aye. Thank you. The staff has provided members of the board with draft minutes before the meeting.

[00:11:29] Is there a motion to approve the minutes as presented to the board? I'll leave second. Ms. McPherson. Aye. Mr. Robinson. Aye. Dr. Bridges. Aye. Mrs. Kilgore. And chair votes aye.

[00:11:45] Wonderful. The board appreciates being able to feature our wonderful arts programs across the Commonwealth by having student performance at our meetings. I will now ask Ms. McPherson to introduce our guests. Middle School Percussion Ensemble under the direction of Michael Bell and Brian Peaty and the Gilded Sleeve Middle School Snare Drum Trio under the direction of Andrea Fedgley and Brian Peaty.

[00:12:19] Both groups represent the Newport News School Division. Today's performance includes two pieces. First, the Panther Percussion Ensemble will perform Two Dollar Window. This piece is performed under percussion instrumentation found in middle school level band music.

[00:12:39] The second piece will be performed by the Snare Drum Trio. They will be playing an original piece titled Triumphant Trio. This original piece was written by the three students performing here today. Also in attendance to support the Newport News Middle School Percussion Ensembles is the Visual and Performing Arts Supervisor, Mrs. Katie Sheehan-Smith, and the Music Specialist, Mr. Tony Mata.

[00:13:08] We thank you for the opportunity to perform for you, which is what they have conveyed, and we hope you all enjoy.

[00:18:11] middle school the uh the passage middle school percussion ensemble and the gilvers league middle

[00:25:16] school snare drum trio for their wonderful performance it is a true pleasure to have our scholars stand in front of us which is not easy um with those big drums that were were their instruments were almost bigger than them but for them to perform was a true pleasure So thank you. And for all the music teachers and music leaders who are not watching, but who are out there doing the great work, we appreciate you.

[00:25:46] It is also our pleasure today to welcome the members of the Virginia Department of Education's Aspiring Special Education Leadership Academy to the meeting today as guests. This could not have been more fortuitous. I was a special education teacher. I just celebrated my 30th anniversary homecoming reunion last weekend, and I had fond remembrances of my time studying special education.

[00:26:15] but last night I was like, I need to get a refresher. I literally downloaded a whole audible book around special education 101. And I thought, man, if I had known y'all would be here today, I could have just come to you and gotten all of my information instead of downloading my audible. And so we are incredibly appreciative of you all being here and the work that you do.

[00:26:37] Members are from the cohort 19 meeting. This is the 19th year of the academy, which was established in 2008 with a purpose to influence the positive outcomes of Virginia students with disabilities by helping them to identify and prepare potential leaders for future succession planning and administrative positions in special education. As of 2024, approximately 470 individuals have participated in ACELA. Is that how you guys call it? Okay, good. Thank you. Each year brings about

[00:27:14] a heavy volume of applications seeking to be a part of this exciting leadership and development opportunity. The board would also like to recognize Mrs. Angela Neely, who serves as the director of ACELA. Angela, are you out there? I'm going to wave her hand. Wonderful. Thank you.

[00:27:32] Angela is a longtime Virginia educator, experienced director of special education mentor, and an allied professional partner. Her experiences and leadership are highly complementary of the Acela

goals, which are grounded in the Council for Exceptional Children's competency standards for special education administrators. The board looks forward to the continued meaningful work of Acela and the agency's collaboration with George Mason University and the many partners and friends of the academy who give their time and resources to help shape the next generation of leaders of special education in the Commonwealth. So on behalf of

[00:28:10] the board, thank you very much for your leadership and your commitment serving our exceptional learners. Thank you. With that, we will now transition to the board recognition of the Virginia K-12 World Language Teacher of the Year. Mr. Robinson. Thank you, President Ashton. It is my pleasure to introduce Ms. Teresa Torgoff, a French teacher at the H.B. Woodlawn Secondary

[00:28:46] program in Arlington Public Schools. Bonjour. And the 2026 recipient of the David Cox Flava Award for Excellence in World Language Teaching, as well as Virginia's 2026 World Language Teacher of the Year. Ms. Torgoff is known for her remarkable ability to create a classroom where students feel both challenged and deeply supported. As one parent shared, she is one of those teachers

[00:29:21] who make an impression moment the moment you meet her because she genuinely loves her work, and it shows. The spirit comes through in every level she teaches, from beginning French to AP courses where she builds confidence, curiosity, and meaningful cultural understanding. Beyond her classroom, Ms. Torgoff contributes widely to the world language profession. She has authored materials for French learners, led professional learners for teachers across Virginia, and presented at regional and national conferences.

[00:29:54] Colleagues affirm her as a generous mentor whose insight strengthens curriculum and instructional practice. Students and families consistently describe her as a trusted guide whose influence extends beyond academics.

[00:30:10] We are honored to recognize Ms. Torgoff today for her exceptional dedication to world language education and for the positive lasting difference she makes in the lives of her students, colleagues, and community. Trey Bien, bravo.

[00:30:30] I'll give you this wonderful certificate today, which doesn't at all summarize all the amazing work that you've done, but if you would join us after for a brief picture, that would be great.

[00:30:47] Thank you. Okay, now the board would also like to recognize the Virginia Distinguished Service Award for World Language. Mrs. Kilgore, will you please read the recognition? Good morning.

[00:31:03] I'm not sure I'm quite as peppy as Mr. Robinson, but I'll try to be peppy. It is my pleasure to introduce Mrs. Catherine T. Sue Robertson, a lifelong Latin educator and one of Virginia's most respected leaders in world language education and the 2026 recipient of the 2026 Helen Warnier Burke Distinguished Service Award. Mrs. Robertson's career spans more than four decades of outstanding service to students and the profession. For 38 years at Midlothian High School and in her continued service after retirement, she inspired generations

[00:31:42] of learners to develop a love of Latin and classical studies. Her leadership extends statewide and nationally through her work with the National Latin Exam, the American Classical League, the National Junior Classical League, and the Classical Association of Virginia. As Lieutenant Governor Hashmi wrote in her letter of support for Sue's nomination for this award, Ms. Robertson represents the

very best of Virginia's educators. Her colleagues describe her as a thoughtful mentor whose deep understanding of how students think has strengthened assessments and instructional

[00:32:22] materials used across the country. Her community service reflects the same spirit of dedication, including her leadership in creating a new welcome center that helps ensure every visitor to her church feels seen and welcomed. We are honored to recognize Mrs. Robertson today for her extraordinary service to the world language profession and for the profound impact she has made on students, educators, and communities across Virginia. Congratulations, Ms. Robertson.

[00:32:58] After you receive your award, if you would both just join us briefly outside, that would be great.

[00:33:02] thank all of our musicians as well as our world language teachers being able to teach our young

[00:36:59] people another language another lens on the world is greatly appreciated we will now transition to the public comment portion of our meeting as stated in the board's bylaws it is a pleasure of the board to accept public comment on all matters related to public education in virginia before we begin today i want to share a few comments about the manner which public comment will be conducted i ask that you model professionalism dignity and respect for others as you share your thoughts today as adults it is important that we model respectful

[00:37:36] civil public discourse for our students the children who are either in attendance today or viewing the the stream now or in the future when you begin please provide your name role, affiliation and where you live in Virginia.

[00:37:55] All remarks must be directed to the chair, not to any other individual. Speakers will have three minutes to share their remarks. You'll notice that there is a timer on the screens will begin when three minutes is in green. At one minute, the screen will turn yellow.

[00:38:12] The screen will turn red when time is up. At that point, please close your remarks promptly. Speakers may provide copies of their comments to Mr. Joe Cook right here in the front, the department's regulatory and board coordinator.

[00:38:29] All written comments received during public comment will be collected and provided to the board as soon as possible after public comment. You may also email a copy of your remarks to the board at boe@doe.virginia.gov.

[00:38:47] I have here six names who have signed up. I'll call them three at a time. First, I have Scott Braiband, Wendy Little, and Keisha Roberts. Are you here? We'll go in that order. Thank you. Good morning.

[00:39:03] President Ashen, Superintendent Conway, and members of the Board of Education, my name is Scott Braibrand. I'm Executive Director for the Virginia Association of School Superintendents. I live in Lynchburg, Virginia, and on behalf of all of our superintendents in Virginia, I bring the following feedback around today's agenda.

[00:39:20] First, the board meeting dates for 2027. Bass appreciates having the board's 2027 calendar of meetings so we can plan our own meetings and activities for next year, and we look forward to returning to your new location downtown in the new year. The next thing is the first review of the HQIM materials for both English and science.

[00:39:40] Thank you for sharing this first review and the timeline for the review of these materials for both the English and science subject areas. These HQIM materials are a key foundation for ensuring the academic success of all of our students, and the review of these materials, your review is deeply appreciated. We will provide any additional feedback on this timeline and process as appropriate at your next board meeting. We also appreciate your Wednesday work session review of the VDOE Strategic Plan Draft Framework, as well as your work around agency-wide school

[00:40:16] improvement. The VDOE Strategic Plan Framework Draft was shared by Superintendent Conway just earlier this week at our superintendent's FAST Fall Conference, and we'll continue to review and provide feedback as this plan is both finalized and implemented. We also share the VDOE's desire to improve the school improvement process, and we'll provide ongoing feedback around that as well.

[00:40:38] We also want to thank Superintendent Conway not only for attending the Fall Conference, but sending her team out to Admington last week for the Southwest Leadership Conference to engage superintendents and their educational leaders. Finally, as a reminder from our comments last meeting, we support us to federal identification for school improvement efforts affect a school's SPSF performance category, and we also support the JLARC recommendation regarding the rebalancing of the overall weight of student growth indicators relative to indicators measuring student proficiency on state assessments in elementary and middle schools. We appreciate very much your

[00:41:18] engagement with us and we look forward to continued partnership in the months ahead. Thank you very much. Thank you. Miss Little and then Keisha Roberts or Liz Negro. Greetings. My name is Wendy Little. The whole nation knows me. This is my son Aaron Little and his last graduation picture which was pre-k in Chesterfield County. Last one. The IDEA was an

[00:41:57] act guaranteeing by condition of chesterfield county public schools public funding for idea and yours there's real human cost to this it is insurmountable this is the fraudulent lawsuit that has been keeping him without remedy for years it's fraudulent it's fraudulent

[00:42:28] it's fraudulent does anybody understand what that means it's fraudulent so everybody said my name is is wendy little i want to be sure chesterfield virginia my son is aaron little e-r-y-n-l-i-t-t-l-e he was refused compensatory education he was refused corrective actions completion by no later than one year no later than one year no later than one year and then this is i'm handing you

[00:43:00] indisputable evidence of state and federal grants fraud indisputable evidence of brought upon the United States government because of the inactions of people who knew better. This is indisputable evidence. And then you got federal corrective actions and manipulated that to the superintendent

[00:43:31] to throw Aaron Little under the bus with nothing. This is unconscionable. I mean, our kids, so many kids, they can't read, they can't write, they can't math. Makes me wonder who is running whatever at the VDOE that can't read in math and know what one year is. Compensatory education was required to be provided in one year. This is indisputable evidence. And through your partners, your partners, through your partners, Sands Anderson Law, Blankenship and Keith Law, Williams-Mullin Law,

[00:44:07] and Eckert Seaman Law, through your partners, I believe that these are high crimes that have been committed. Aaron Little still deserves remedy. He is now entitled to over four years compensatory education and somebody needs to step up to the plate and make that happen instead of all these circles of attorneys who just profit from keeping this stuff up thank you wendy little

[00:44:37] chesterfield virginia thank you thank you is liz here then i have joe lofted and rodney jordan in that order good morning president ashton superintendent conway and members of the board my name is dr liz nigro and i am the senior policy analyst at vea or virginia education association currently residing here in richmond thank you for the opportunity to comment the vea values

[00:45:12] the goals outlined in the video strategic plan and appreciate your presentation yesterday reaching them will require supporting educators and school staff who serve our students on a daily basis additionally these asks will require adequate and equitable funding within the plan we appreciate the emphasis on educators and learning environments we recommend two other measures of progress first data from the virginia school survey of climate and working conditions to better capture teachers lived experience within the classroom and second teacher retention rates ideally by licensure

[00:45:48] pathway next we appreciate the plan's commitment to align funding and evidence-based resources to support the highest need students and divisions we are glad to see additional funding attached to agency wide school improvement plans this is critical because we know accountability without additional funding will not deliver the results that we all want this is also where the board holds unique power under article 8 section 2 of constitution of virginia the board is charged with prescribing standards of quality subject to revision only by the general assembly in your next review of the standards we urge you to build funding recommendations directly into your soq

[00:46:27] prescriptions for priority three as the department invests in new systems including artificial intelligence we ask for a continued focus on data security to protect the privacy of students and school staff the recent cyber attack on richmond public schools showed how exposed student and staff information can be finally we welcome priority four's commitment to engagement educators want to continue to be partners in this work at the table early and often particularly as school funding decisions are made. Thank you for your time and we appreciate your service to Virginia

[00:47:04] students and teachers. Thank you. Joe Loftead and then Rodney Jordan. Good morning. Thank you for the opportunity to share what I see in classrooms. My name is Joe Loftead and I primarily serve Stafford and Richmond County Schools as a success lead for great minds. That means that I'm a coach.

[00:47:30] I'm a critical friend in classrooms every day helping teachers implement high-quality instructional materials. Great Minds creates K-8 math and ELA curricular products such as Eureka Math, Witten Wisdom, and Arts and Letters. Our CEO, John White, is a former Louisiana State Superintendent who helped lead the state's work connecting standards to align classroom materials.

[00:47:56] Today's consent agenda includes additions to the Virginia Literacy Act of approved core instructional programs for K-5. Arts and Letters is not on that list. We took the review seriously and refined the program to meet Virginia's goals. In January, we will release Arts and Letters with Reading Foundations built on the research of Reading Reimagined. It builds word recognition skills so students can decode independently, strengthen memory through structured practice, and develop fluency that carries into whole books.

[00:48:30] We hope to be on the list next year. But why does this matter? Because I see what happens when students read full, complex texts that build knowledge from one topic to the next. Two years ago, I began working with a district with a long history of low results.

[00:48:46] The teachers were working hard, but the materials had only some students reaching grade level. Recently, I observed a third-grade classroom in that same district. Students were reading The Fantastic Undersea Life of Jacques Cousteau. The teacher read the word illuminate and hands went up before she even asked a question.

[00:49:05] One boy said, that sounds like luminous from Amos and Boris. Another student added, I was thinking of bioluminescence in the giant squid. The teacher had supports ready, but she didn't need them. So she asked the harder question, what do all of these three words have in common?

[00:49:23] These students weren't memorizing vocabulary. They were connecting words across books and building knowledge over time. Afterwards, the teacher told me that she was hesitant about the new materials at first, but she trusted the process anyway. Now she believes this is the work her students should be doing.

[00:49:41] This is the shift from some students reaching grade level to all students doing grade level thinking. It's in keeping efforts by the board to raise standards, and we would be welcomed the chance to be part of this approach in the future.

[00:49:58] Thank you. you. Rodney Jordan, thank you. Good morning. President Ashton, Vice President Bridges, members of the Virginia Board of Education, Superintendent Conway. My name is Rodney Jordan.

[00:50:17] I'm here representing the Virginia School Boards Association, bringing greetings on behalf of VSBA President Jean Nichols and Executive Director Gina Patterson. I reside in Norfolk, Virginia. In forming the VSBA Task Force on Students in Schools in Challenging Environments, the VSBA board of directors charged the group to make recommendations to the state board of ed and the state department of ed on how vsba can partner to help challenge schools in virginia and to identify and share research resources and strategies that will empower virginia schools to reach higher levels of student achievement it is through that charge and lens i present these

[00:50:52] comments improving student outcomes in the videoe strategic plan and the board's comprehensive plan include clear, smart student outcome-focused goals, specific, measurable, attainable, results-focused, time-bound. For example, the gap between economically disadvantaged and non-disadvantaged students in third grade reading proficiency, as measured by third grade SOLs, will decline from X percentage points in September 2026 to Y percentage points by September 2030.

[00:51:22] Once adopted by the board, video administration should provide the board with interim SMART goals predictive of the board's adopted student outcome goals and the board should monitor progress toward the adopted goals. Distinguish between student outcomes and adult outcomes. Consider adopting an intentional goal focused on students with disabilities. Frankly, we need more candid discussion about accountability for students with disabilities. We should expect rigorous instruction, appropriate services, and meaningful progress for every student. The question is not whether these students can learn, they can and do. The question is whether our system accurately

[00:51:58] recognizes their learning and gives educators actionable guidance when progress is insufficient. If schools repeatedly receive the same designation despite strong implementation, the board should examine both the effectiveness of the interventions and adequacy of the measures.

[00:52:13] Adult strategies and inputs. We applaud the reimagining of agency-wide school improvement. As you review capacity, consider regional support offices and teams as part of school improvement. We also ask that you address teacher talent gaps, and we believe the investments made in the Virginia Literacy Act provide an opportunity to align further student literacy outcomes statewide while honoring the uniqueness in local goal setting and decision making. And for the sake of time, I just want to mention two other things. Communicating results, we can continue to see 100%

[00:52:51] accredited and fully accredited presented as the headline. We think it's important that we be able to distinguish compliance with student learning, and perhaps the VDOE can help provide some language with local school divisions in that regard. And then lastly, about a decade ago, VSBA, VDOE, local universities, and others hosted a summit titled Practices and Promises for Schools in Challenged Environments. VSBA is at the ready to support that type of effort in 2027, and we would be pleased to be your partners in that endeavor. Thank you. Thank you. Is there

[00:53:27] anyone else who would like to testify for public comment okay that concludes our public comment portion of the agenda we will now move to our consent agenda items a final review to certify the list of qualified persons for the office of division of superintendent of schools and b final review of the financial report on literacy fund and updates to the first priority waiting list

[00:54:04] is there a motion to weigh first review and approve the items on the consent agenda right miss mcpherson hi mr robinson hi dr bridges hi mrs kilgore and chair votes aye thank you you're now moving to our action discussion items item c mr chapman our director of board relations thank you so much president ashton members of the board superintendent conway

[00:54:41] this proposal for the 2027 meeting date so the board of education has been vetted with staff you'll notice that the meetings schedule that's proposed includes meetings in january march april may july september october and december these are the months where the board schedules align most defiantly for for quorum numbers um of course we are avoiding the february meeting mainly because of the way that that would overlap with the the legislative session and in keeping with the the recent tradition the november board meeting being particularly difficult to schedule with uh with holidays around the end of the month we're we're going

[00:55:20] for the the first little bit of december um instead of that november meeting thank you mr chadman board members are there any questions yes dr bridges i want to thank you for surveying us all and trying to corral all of the schedules i do want to add a caveat i completely improved approved the timeline um this year i was hoping that we could have some representation at the national association of state boards of education but it's their conferences today um and was yesterday so complete overlap with that it's right up the road in dc it would uh offer us some of the

[00:55:57] professional development that we've been talking about as a board so that we're modeling um uh continual improvement as a governance body and so that's a long way of saying they don't have their 2027 dates up yet i will bring back to you forward as soon as i do it's typically october so we i may be asking for an amendment to the timeline but hopefully well in advance this time so we can yeah so thank you thank you any other comments okay thank you is there a motion to approve the

[00:56:28] proposed 2027 board of education meeting dates so moved is there a second second great mrs mcpherson

[00:56:39] Mr. Robinson? Hi. Dr. Bridges? Hi. Mrs. Kilgore? Aye. And chair votes aye. Thank you. All right. We will move to item D. Mr. Chapman, you're up again. Thank you so much, President Ashton. This item is a fast track regulatory action that we're presenting on first and final review, in large part due to the lack of discretion. This is really a cleanup item. We don't think that there is really a lot at stake here in terms of the board exercising any particular

[00:57:11] particular direction or discretion. Essentially what happens when these child day center regulations, the general procedures governing licensing applications and background checks for child day centers went for publication. There was a small little difference in the definition of two statutorily defined terms that we would like to align. Essentially, instead of using the phrase under the age of 13, the definitions in the regs uses 13 years of age or younger, which includes the 13 year old year that is not included in the statutory definition.

[00:57:41] In practice, this is not a not an issue because the statutory definition controls, and in a sense, has more authority than the board's definition. So this is really just a quick alignment to the statute. We are also fixing one rep reference to the statewide fire prevention code, which in in the same way that the board updates its regulations.

[00:58:01] They just promulgated a new chapter. So we're just fixing the reference. so we think that this one is appropriate to get moving and do the corrections as soon as possible just to make sure that there is alignment great thanks Mr. Chapman board members are there any questions okay is there a motion to approve the fast track regulatory action to make technical corrections and delegate to staff the authority to make any changes necessary to comply with the Administrative Process Act of the Virginia Register Act live second that's a second Ms. McPherson

[00:58:39] thank you um miss mcpherson okay mr robinson hi dr bridges hi mrs kilgore and chair votes aye thank you very much thank you so much all right we're on to item e the first review of the timeline for the science textbooks with high quality instructional materials review dr wallace i thought i saw you thank you dr wask hey good morning president ashton superintendent conway

[00:59:18] and members of the board. Thank you for allowing us allowing me to to bring to you the materials. The first review for the science textbook and HQIM review and adoption timeline.

[00:59:34] The standards of learning define what students are expected to know and be able to do at each grade level and course. High quality instructional materials are curricula and educational materials that are aligned to the standards and reflect evidence-based practices for teaching and learning.

[00:59:51] Standards and HQIM work together to fulfill the expectations defined in the Code of Virginia and the priorities set forth in the Board's comprehensive plan. The review and revision of Virginia's textbook and HQIM process is aligned to priority one of the Board's comprehensive plan to set and help every learner meet high expectations by adopting and supporting the implementation of comprehensive, clear, and rigorous academic standards through its selection of textbooks in HQIM. A little background on the science standards of learning because some members

[01:00:27] are new, so indulge me for just a minute. The science, 2018 science standards of learning were approved by the Board of Education on October 18, 2018. There was a delay in the full implementation of the 2018 Science Standards of Learning due to the pandemic in 2020. When the review process shortly

began afterwards for the updated standards of 2025, the review team recommended a stay with those 2018 standards, which cover content from kindergarten through grade 8, as well as earth

[01:01:06] science, biology, chemistry, and physics. The 2025 Science Standards of Learning focused on the expanded high school courses of which we had content guidelines for, but we did not have formal standards of learning. And these courses are used for graduation. These courses are at a higher level. They include your second level courses of like biology too. So that'd be your anatomy, your physics too, going deep into astronomy, meteorology, that kind of thing.

[01:01:38] And so they are typically at a higher level and the content standards are typically addressed through introductory college-level textbooks. Divisions usually offer these courses as dual enrollment and therefore using textbooks recommended by a partnering institute of higher education. Therefore, the focus of our textbook review will be on those 2018 science standards of learning courses, as well as environmental science, which is more of a level one course that lacked standards, that is from the 2025 science standards of learning. Rest assured,

[01:02:13] When we review the standards of learning for the next review of science, we will combine the two together and we'll no longer have two sets of standards. But for the time being, because of the way they are adopted and they adopted by this board, we go with the year in which they were adopted.

[01:02:30] So that might be why you see two different dates for science, and I felt it worthy to explain that for the board members who may not have been here during that adoption process. In review of the timeline, you will notice several steps along the way to engage with educators and other stakeholders to assist with the review of materials.

[01:02:49] The process includes training for potential vendors to understand the requirements of the new process, training for those who will be reviewing materials, as well as additional training for schools and divisions to understand what the final approval of materials looks like, what's been approved, what the process was to approve those materials.

[01:03:08] We anticipate being able to bring materials before the board in July for final approval and ask that you receive this item for first review. There's a clarification in July, December.

[01:03:27] It's first review now. First review now. You think it'll come back? Well, final review. So final review of this item in December. Final review of the materials in July of next year, according to the timeline. Thank you for the clarification.

[01:03:43] Board members, are there any other questions? Thank you, Dr. Wallace. Mr. Robinson, were you leaning? Okay. We will accept this for first review and have an update in December and then following July. Right. There'll be other meetings in between July.

[01:04:02] Before that. For sure. You'll see the materials before July, but that's just the end of the timeline. Great. Thank you. All right, let's move on to item F, the first review of the timeline for the English 6 through 12 textbooks and high quality instructional materials review.

[01:04:20] Thank you again for allowing me to present a first review of the English 6 through 12 textbook and HQIM review and adoption timeline. The board approved the 2024 English Standards of Learning in March 2024, after which the board then approved the Department of Education to begin the process for review of the 6 through 12 English textbooks in April of 2024.

[01:04:47] The department followed the revised timeline for the state approval process for English and the textbook criteria for English at that time to conduct the review. In 2025, the General Assembly enacted chapters 680 and 683, commonly referred to as House Bill 2777, the Code of Virginia 22.1-253.13.1 in Standard 1.

[01:05:14] It made changes to the textbook and other high-quality instructional materials review process, of which this board approved, that are used by school divisions as the basis for their local curriculum, for instruction in English K-612, mathematics K-12, science K-12, and history K-12.

[01:05:33] These changes require that each local school board adopt and implement textbooks and other HQIM in these areas, and that each educational prep program provides training of individuals seeking initial licensure around HQIM. This will be a mid-cycle review, which is something new that we have not done before. The prior materials for English 6 through 12 were adopted in 2024, December. The new legislation came into effect in July of 2025, and so therefore we are bringing for a mid-cycle review of our English 6 through 12 textbooks and materials.

[01:06:10] The mid-cycle review will allow VDOE to expand on our current list, which will remain in effect, so divisions that have already adopted will not be impacted. They will be allowed to continue using those materials. However, we do know of divisions who are at a point where they will be adopting materials due to contract expirations.

[01:06:32] Part of this is because when we adopted the 2024 textbooks and materials, it was on a little bit of an accelerated timeline, so we may not have had publishers that were able to align their materials to our new standards, and also there is the new HQIM law that is in effect.

[01:06:53] So for that reason, we're bringing forth a second review process that incorporates the new HQIM process, as well as gives an opportunity for publishers to submit items that are different from what we reviewed prior.

[01:07:10] The potential adoption of additional materials will allow those divisions who have not yet or are right there at the adoption cycle to have an additional list of materials that they can choose from the board approved list.

[01:07:25] Similar to the science approval of HQIM, this meets our strategic planning goal of goal two and we anticipate being able to bring materials, bring this item back in December for final review.

[01:07:41] We'll do the same timeline for science. They are two different educator teams. They focus on different content. And so we will have them running parallel processes. And we anticipate bringing the final review of those materials to you next July. At that point, and at this point, we just ask that you receive this item for first review.

[01:08:04] Thank you, Dr. Wallace. We're members, are there any questions? Mr. Robinson? Thank you for this thoughtful approach and for, in response to legislation, ensuring that Virginia's educators have access to materials that may not have been approved that are high quality during the previous process. For clarification, there's currently 67 already approved for 612 textbooks, is that correct? And we're looking to expand that list,

[01:08:39] potentially to further not not review any of the 67 on whether they oh no sir we their grandfathered in their grandfathered in um uh so my my curiosity more long term not to uh impact

whether we we heard from a potential new material uh in public comment that could be could be strong so i'm fully supportive of of widening that net uh and i'm curious about you know moving from 67 to perhaps over 70, that's a lot of choices. That's a lot to sift through in determining what's most likely to

[01:09:17] have impact for our students. And I'm curious if it would be possible to consider over time, not just an approved list, but possibly some sort of tiering where with the department and your expertise uh you know we might consider um you know still allowing anything that meets a certain bar to be used but somehow signaling to the field here's where we see the greatest impact possibly even incentivizing those curriculum in different ways uh such as uh the professional development

[01:09:53] that that is provided so with our procurement laws in virginia we do have to be careful about how we signal which materials are quality above other materials. So what we do is present the facts to divisions. We do present the rubrics that have been been allowed. So we when we review, we review with a set of rubrics around alignment and then with this new review process we will review with a set of requirements around the definition, Virginia's definition of high quality

[01:10:28] instructional materials so those rubrics will be based off of that lengthy definition when we release the materials for approval in virginia we will release um those rubrics along with the materials so that divisions can then make decisions best informed for their situations and that's wonderful i i was not aware that those rubrics were publicly released i think that's that's excellent practice um and uh would would still encourage over time for whichever one score

[01:11:03] highest on that process consideration over time of how we might further incent uh through the professional development or other supports we provide particularly to our most uh underserved divisions uh you know again their choice within procurement law uh but is there a way to provide additional support in the uh towards the curricula that and materials that have the highest rating this is a consideration thank you thanks robinson superintendent calmly yeah no thank you mr

[01:11:37] robinson yeah i mean i think it's it's important to note um and the reason for bringing this at first review and then um as dr wallace noted that this is a little unusual in opening this up mid-cycle but i think we are as an organization thinking about how do we take these laws that have been passed and implement them and that requires us to think differently about uh the approach i think um and there's two uh uh major uh impacts that are sort of affecting this work obviously the

[01:12:12] first is the extension of the virginia literacy act and then all of the data that we are getting through the extraordinary work of our school divisions around vowels four through eight and so as we think about um whether it's tiering or i think as dr wallace noted while staying well within procurement laws how do we use some of that information around where we know students are struggling and whether or not there is an opportunity to be more clear about which resources might better help uh meet the needs of virginia students and so i think there is uh certainly a

[01:12:46] willingness to kind of think out of the box around that, in addition to recognizing that we broadly have to approve a set of resources. And then I think the second key piece is there is a very, there's a line in the HQIM law that really provides for going a step further with school divisions that are that are identified as in need and as we think through that review we are now gathering through the accreditation process what resources school divisions are using we can look

[01:13:21] specifically at you know grades 6 through 12 and then as we sort of see growth you know sort of recognize that and allow you know and take a step back and as we see lack of growth or even trending in the in a downward direction is to think about um how we might intervene and thinking about which curriculum is being used and whether or not we are encouraging uh folks to think about other ones so i think it's still brand new it just went into effect on july 1st but as dr wallace noted the important step is getting this uh open mid process and then thinking about how do we use uh some of

[01:14:00] these changes in laws to think differently with it with the priority towards as you described mr represent those those uh divisions in schools in greatest need yep um thank you uh i also just and then we have one more item but just appreciate the mid-cycle review and not waiting which just gives the field time to review um we're we're just on the heels of receiving the data from last year and so i think this will allow leaders in school divisions time to really get out ahead and plan for the following year so i just want to applaud the the mid-cycle review um yep ms mcpherson sorry

[01:14:39] i wanted to know whether we undertake the review textbook materials we're doing it every three years every five years is there like a process and then do you find that after the review it ends up with vendors producing more often new textbooks versus just additional instructional material that could be used as a crosswalk as opposed to school divisions having to go back out so

[01:15:13] what is the time frame and what do you normally find as a result of the analysis so in the past our typical timeline has aligned with the standards review process that is kind of shifting now so in the past so this is the very first time we've ever done a mid-cycle review for any content area except for core k5 which is coming up next which is in response to the literacy act so aside from the virginia literacy act this is the first time that our other core content areas

[01:15:49] have gone through a mid-cycle review so that the typical timeline in the past had been the standards are adopted in year one. In year two, we take that year, it allows publishers a little time to adopt or adjust materials, and then we begin the adoption process. And so we adopt kind of in like year two, three, in between, right? And then from that, divisions set their own adoption processes. So typically, like in year three, they would begin their adoption processes at the local level because they don't just, they have their own division policies around textbook adoptions.

[01:16:29] Those policies may be just select from the BDOE list. Some of those policies include their own internal reviews of materials where they get copies just like we do, and they select the copies they want to get based on the materials we've put online around the rubrics. They might review two or three sets of materials. They might review more. It also depends on what's available by grade level as to what they're reviewing. So if you have multiple sets in one grade level, that's going to have a different feel for a review. For our sake, VDOE, we would not adopt again

[01:17:03] until the next seven-year cycle of the standards of learning. So with the new legislation and the changes to the textbook and HQIM definition for Virginia, we felt it necessary to go ahead and do a mid-cycle review in response to the legislation, as well as to provide additional opportunities for

[01:17:26] vendors to send materials. Because this past adoption cycle, we started immediately after the approval of the standards of learning, which did make it difficult for vendors to make some shifts in alignment to their materials. So this, this opportunity then provides, you know, an option for division for vendors who may have made shifts in alignment to now apply. Typically, when we adopt, we are adopting a set of materials that we have reviewed and nothing else.

[01:17:57] so if division if vendors do have supplemental materials that they then introduce that is supplemental to what they're adopting and they follow their local policies to adopt and use those materials so we don't prohibit them from using those materials because they're supplemental to the what was adopted and and we don't have the guidelines for that uh that those supplemental materials it's other materials that they can use if they see necessary in their school divisions

[01:18:25] So that's typically how it's worked in the past, and as a division staff member who has done many textbook adoptions, I can tell you that we typically, the field typically relies on what the VDOE has reviewed and approved, because it's a pretty stringent and rigorous process of review, and it sets vendors to have, you know, high quality standards that they have to meet in order to get approved in Virginia.

[01:18:51] And that is K-12 all content areas, including our core literacy programs. Okay, great. We now can officially move to item G, if that's okay.

[01:19:07] The review of the Virginia Literacy Act core instructional program. Don't you just love how people pop out from the table? Thank you again for letting me stand before you for three items in a row. I think this is a first for me. Usually I'm popping in and out.

[01:19:24] We are here to present to you the first review of additional core materials for K-5 literacy programs. So what the previous item was, was for English 6 through 12 materials. Now we are thinking about K-5 materials that supports our Virginia Literacy Act.

[01:19:45] I have with me the curriculum lead from UVA's Virginia Literacy Partnership, Ann Eaton. have seen her before come to the board with these items. The Virginia Literacy Act, just a little history. I think you heard a little bit of this last time, but just like to level set. It was passed in 2022 and expanded in 2023. It focuses on improving literacy outcomes for all students in the Commonwealth. The VLA requires that each local school board shall provide a program of literacy instruction that is aligned with science-based reading research and provides

[01:20:20] evidence-based literacy instruction to students in kindergarten through grade eight. To support school divisions to comply with this requirement, the Virginia Literacy Act requires that the Department of Education develop a list of instructional programs in literacy, including core, supplemental, and intervention programs that consist of evidence-based literacy instruction and aligned with the science-based reading research. VLP, our partners in this work, has conducted the fifth cycle of program reviews. So that is the other exception. That is the

[01:20:56] exception to this rule that we talked about on timelines. The core instructional review process is unique to Virginia and consists of two phases, each with discrete rubrics for each grade level.

[01:21:13] Initial rubric drafts were developed by VLP, reviewed by national experts, Virginia Higher education partnerships of partners and Virginia educators. Final rubrics are posted online, and the review process was designed to align with Virginia's textbook adoption process.

[01:21:30] Reviews were conducted by Virginia educators comprised of competitively selected teams of administrators, reading specialists and division representatives, and teachers from all eight regions across the commonwealth. Teams were led by literacy experts facilitating the process.

[01:21:49] reviewers conducted independent reviews using comprehensive rubrics and facilitators met with review teams weekly for discussion of norming and building consensus facilitators compiled final

rubric results consulting as a as a virginia or excuse me as a facilitator team to consistently across all programs have that consistency in the submissions so that we everybody is as level and has that consistent understanding of the rubric as well as the scores

[01:22:22] within those rubrics the review process resulted in the current recommended core instructional program guide being submitted to to you guys for review and then as additional rounds are completed we will bring this forward to you again for approval i would like to now turn you to the presentation, which hopefully you are able to access. And I think due to some technology website issues, we're not able to put it here for others to see. So you will have to go to your

[01:23:01] materials. So just as a review of the K-5 instructional program guide, we wanted to give you kind of an outline of that process. You heard a snippet of that last month when Dr. Solari came and talked about the process in her presentation. But this gives you what the timeline is for this current review cycle. And so you can see we began our inaugural review cycle in fall of '22.

[01:23:31] We ran cycle one in spring of '23, cycle two in spring of '24, cycle three in fall of '24, and then in fall of 25 just a year ago Anne and I were together presenting to you some supplemental and intervention programs and so this is cycle five which brings to you for the third time the k5 or one time it was k3 the next time it was k5 core instructional programs for

[01:24:06] recommendations to the board when we look at the review process some of this I have already mentioned and so i'm not going to read that specifically but do know that this is a very rigorous and comprehensive program review process it is unique to virginia and so we've had vendors say in other states xyz but in virginia the review process is different and it is a little stricter a little bit more confined right and so we want to bring the best products for literacy as instruction to to our classrooms in Virginia.

[01:24:42] We have examined rubrics in other states when we developed our rubrics. We sought and incorporated feedback from those national experts. We simulated the program review using rubrics that were available at that time. So we piloted it prior to being implemented in '22 and then posted the rubrics online.

[01:25:01] And of course they align with our legislation. I've kind of touched on the process of the review. So I'm not gonna go into detail there. And then so slide six, if you're following along, you can see there are two phase process. It's four weeks in phase one. And in that process, we ensure programs are aligned to science based reading research, as well as our Virginia standards of learning.

[01:25:26] So our team at BDOE, who is, has worked on the development of those standards, took that part of the review process, while VLP led the science based reading research part of that process. effort between the agency and BLP, and then we use that broad rubric to evaluate the program and eliminate programs that clearly misaligned with the science-based reading research.

[01:25:51] So even if they align to the standards of learning and they did not align to the science-based reading research, they were eliminated from that process. In phase two, Ann's team of reviewers delved into the programs and all of the materials to determine how the program aligned to science-based reading research, and then used additional detailed evaluation components to facilitate that review process.

[01:26:19] On slide seven, you can see we offer an opportunity for appeals. So if, for example, a vendor does not meet the criteria of the review, there is an appeal process whereby they receive feedback and have the opportunity to produce more data or evidence to support where they were lacking and they

decide where they want to appeal so we review what they appeal and not beyond what that appeal is providers um you know where the review teams take the provider information that has been submitted to review that appeal and then make

[01:26:55] a final decision upon that appeal and we did have a situation where a vendor this time did appeal and and we did, we weren't able to add materials to this list. So the process does work. In addition, the last slide, slide eight, the alignment with our textbook and HQIM adoption, due to the new legislation and the new Virginia process, we have incorporated some changes into the process that did not impact the rubric, but did impact, as I said, demonstrating that correlation directly to our standards of learning so that that process follows our six through 12 process for English as well.

[01:27:34] And then additional certification forms that vendors may have to submit that helps us with our procurement processes around textbook adoptions for school divisions, as well as ensuring high quality materials and certifications from vendors on the research base of their materials.

[01:27:54] Public examination will be allowed before the final review. And so that is why we'll be bringing this item back to you In January, we had to allow time for the announcement of the public comment period and then the 30 day public comment period and because of the short timeline, even though it's between October and December, it is still a truncated timeline.

[01:28:16] And so therefore, we will bring the materials back to you in January for your final review. In addition to the PowerPoint presentation in your packets electronically, you can see attachment one, which does include the materials that are being reviewed for final review.

[01:28:34] And that lovely instructional guide, which I know Anne always loves to talk about the kids on the front of the instructional guide for the core instructional programs. But you can see the details that are given here, where the strengths were. I think this speaks maybe to Mr. Robinson's comments about providing divisions with a clear view of what was strong in a program and what might suit the needs of that program and what divisions may want to consider for adoption when they look at these materials.

[01:29:05] And so we clearly put out there where people, where the vendor did not meet expectations or met expectations for their programs, aligning strengths and challenges that allow divisions to make their own decisions about what they adopt. And now I will turn it back to you, President Ashton, for any questions, and I'm sure Ann will be happy to answer questions along with me.

[01:29:29] Thank you so much. Board members, are there any questions? Dr. Bridges? Thank you both. I'm just wondering from the perspective, it's hard to grapple with the, we've got layers of what the SOL and SOQs require, now HQIM legislation and VLA legislation.

[01:29:52] If I'm a teacher in the classroom or a school leader trying to figure out this year, and maybe that's a weird case, but, you know, particular materials that I'm going to be using to advance learning in the classroom, how easy is it for me to figure out what to use, given all of the things that y'all are doing?

[01:30:13] The good news is that the Virginia Literacy Act is a part of the same part of the Code of Virginia as the High Quality Instructional Materials Law. Yeah. So the law is within standards of quality one. Right. And so when we talk to divisions and when we train them on HQIM, we are constantly reminding them of the requirements from the Virginia Literacy Act, which falls into that same code of Virginia.

[01:30:38] and we remind them that the requirements, you know, requirements to adopt the core instructional programs, supplemental, and intervention. And that's the main difference, right? For K-5, they must adopt core programs K-5, they must adopt supplemental programs K-8, and they must adopt intervention programs K-8. The core programs for 6 through 12 come from the textbook and HQIM So, they are the requirements with that law is that they they must adopt.

[01:31:18] However, they do divisions do have the option to not adopt from the board approved list. If they use a similar process to the process that the Virginia Department of Education uses to review materials, and so we will post online the rubrics for 6 through 12 that we will be using the rubrics for science, 6 through 12 English and K-12 science, and we will post the Virginia's process that you adopted in July for divisions to use. Divisions have been doing this since the beginning of time, right? They've been adopting materials, and so we have tried to be clear in our professional

[01:31:57] learning with them the difference in adopting 6 through 12, which is required by the HQIM legislation, and the difference of adopting core instructional programs for K-5, supplemental and intervention programs for K-8. In addition, they must put those programs for K-8, intervention and supplemental, and four programs outlined in their division literacy plans. And so we have been working with them since 2023-2024 to really outline what those requirements are for VLA and how that is different from a regular 6-12 adoption. Great. Superintendent Kamlis. Absolutely. I think

[01:32:36] um one of the things that we can bring back to this body is just to sort of where we are i think there's it's uh there have been uh to dr wallace's point there's been a long history of textbook adoption we then had a set of laws that went further than that and although they do provide some flexibility for uh locally generated materials or sort of a different review process process the vast majority of folks are choosing and are choosing sort of a subset of these and so being able to kind of go from what is a very long list to um you know here's what's actually

[01:33:13] being used i would also add that the um the fact that we've been able to stay the course on the virginia literacy act expand it and then with the hqim law which as dr wallace has noted the same code this emphasis on curriculum-based professional learning the idea it is not at the teacher level level that there is selection. It is at the division level, because ultimately the division has to comply with the law around making sure that consistently across the division that the professional learning aligns. But I think when we look, for example, at the world of

[01:33:50] early childhood, although there's a long list of resources, something like 60% are using one resource, right? And so, you know, as we think about the work ahead of us, sort of understanding where we are, to your question, Mr. Robinson, around tiers, thinking about, you know, our level of comfort or sort of identifying if 60% of the system or some similar number is using it, and we know it's strong in this area and maybe less, you know, less aligned in those areas, how do we think about our role to kind of share that information and take things like this program guide, if you

[01:34:26] look at the page on the bottom line and the chart, right, and thinking about where there are real strengths in the resources and where there might be opportunities to supplement to kind of address those gaps. But I know now that we do have from the literacy plans and from the accreditation process more information about what is actually being used, that it would make sense to bring it back to this body so that we're thinking about this in two aspects one is what is approved and then the other is what is actually being used because you know it's not like you know it's

[01:35:01] 70 resources or you know seven or ten resources used across right i mean there's a there's a breakdown and there tend to be sort of a couple of products that are used fairly widely across the commonwealth can i follow up on that i appreciate all of this information i think my my question was probably more basic than y'all were thinking where i'm literally trying to put myself in the shoes of a classroom teacher i think the answer i heard in all of that was i don't i don't necessarily have to go into the law and read the policy i'm dependent on my divisions process but i should be

[01:35:36] able to look on the state website and see that rubric and see oh okay now i see why my division selected this thing that I'm trying to use today um because of this robust state um correct process that that is correct I mean it is essentially the responsibility of the division and this local school board to adopt the local curriculum um and then you know depending on local school division policies some of those policies as I stated might be a direct adoption list and look it's done solely at the division level others might you know include teacher committees parent

[01:36:12] committees which we encourage teacher and parent committees as part of that process and we encourage that even through our newly adopted process and if i'm a classroom teacher who's interested in helping with this process i would see in teachers direct the the upcoming dates for review committee participation yes correct so we'll do a call for um for reviewers if you're interested in being a part of that review and we we typically it ends up being and from the division perspective as well as from the state perspective it it typically ends up being teachers who are

[01:36:50] aspiring to be leaders in their field in their english whether they're going to be curriculum leaders or whether they're going to be division leaders later on but it typically is those teachers that that surface as teacher leaders who then apply for those processes to be on assessment committees sol review committees textbook adoption review committees and we from the state level tend to see a lot of the same people which is good because if they have been through the standards review process and they helped with revisions of the standards they

[01:37:24] deeply understand them and can apply that when they're a part of the textbook and hqim adoption process. And then we acclimate them. We do training. We do training for the educators or stakeholders who are going to be part of those review committees. We do training for our vendors. We do training at the end. We are consistently trying to incorporate training for educators. And so when it gets to that teacher level, we are, as Superintendent Conway alluded to, shifting our focus to relying on some curriculum-based professional

[01:38:00] learning i like to joke and say that's the new acronym that people have to learn now in addition to hqim cbpl and that curriculum-based professional learning is all about the hqim that that specific got to use more than one acronym in a sentence right if you're an educator um so the cbpl is directly related to the adopted hqim that the division is using at that elementary school

[01:38:31] at that middle school. And so it is a direct response and support to teachers being able to implement that HQIM at a greater level, have a greater understanding, an understanding of how you can go between the materials within the units, how you can go in between, you know, the assessments that are there, what's appropriate, where you need to go beyond for a student or a group of students.

[01:38:54] So that professional learning is just really key. And it is a huge shift in what professional learning has been typically in Virginia, where we have in the Code of Virginia, all teachers have to get

professional learning. It has to be in the Division's Improvement Plan, Comprehensive and Plan, that all teachers have to get professional learning. It's required. Teachers love professional learning.

[01:39:12] But what makes this professional learning different is it's more relevant to their day-to-day in and out work and what they're doing in the classroom and how they can adjust instruction on the go. And I think listening to what I did get to listen to from yesterday's meeting, we also rely for our literacy partnerships.

[01:39:31] We also rely on that support of our literacy coaches to help those teachers understand the science-based reading research that then is applied within their HQIM. so we have multiple layers where teachers are being impacted with and supported thank you yes thank you mr robinson first of all i just love this um uh the capacity building happening across the state uh thanks to this partnership between videoe and plp and uh secretary smith uh uh when he presented yesterday about our bold goals and and how we hope to be nation leading um you know

[01:40:10] when they write the case study of why, I think this partnership and what you're demonstrating today and how thoughtful you're being will be part of the reason that we have a chance to do this for Virginia students. I love this guide specifically because you speak to program challenges. And so even these, as I understand it, two that are being put out for public comment that have met expectations, at least in certain grade levels, even those two that met the high bar,

[01:40:50] you're not saying there's a silver bullet. You're saying that even within those, there's much work to be done to make it work for our scholars and so I just want to also appreciate the superintendent's push for bringing back to us where things stand and what's been approved in totality as well as what's being used as well as moving towards a more data-driven effort over time to seeing based on what's being used what are the outcomes that we're seeing you know I know that

[01:41:25] I believe that Alabama has only two K4, I believe, curricula that are approved and therefore they're able to do, to your point about the, for CORE, and therefore that curriculum-based professional development can be much stronger and amplified. And so all that to say, I think this sets the foundation and is deeply appreciated and is excellent work I would say nation-leading process here and I'm excited to help the uh to support the division as it moves to a nation-leading

[01:42:04] effort around implementation support uh that's data-driven on what's actually working thanks Mr. Robinson Superintendent Conway absolutely and I think the um other only piece that I would note here and I know we heard this referred to in public comment is that it is important to think about this and I know that there's um some examples uh and some valuing of a of a smaller list I want to be very careful that um this is a two-way street in that we have also seen and this

[01:42:36] is a relatively new practice across the the nation around very sort of more rigorous reviews but then vendors in part have been responsive and so I think you know some folks measure success in in terms of the narrowing of that list, I think other folks would say, if getting on to this list and being more widely adopted means making adjustments to ensure that it is aligned with the most up-to-date science of reading, science of math, et cetera, et cetera, is also a positive

[01:43:09] outcome. There are real switching costs in terms of, as Dr. Bridges noted, to kind of using something for a couple of years and then trying to switch the whole system over. And so I think as we look at where we are today, we look at other states and we'll always look at sort of other states, particularly

those that have seen significant gains as measured by national assessment tools, but also think about where we can use these laws and this process to encourage vendors to be responsive. And as Dr. Wallace noted, if that means making some adjustments to review timelines to do that in order to kind of get the resources that are actually being used in classrooms up to

[01:43:48] that with that bar is also kind of a viable strategy worth considering so i think we really looking at where we are and then continuing to evaluate and come back to this body is going to be going to be key there are no further questions we will i want to say thank you and we will accept this item for first review and see you in future meetings january no no not january maybe next or we'll just see you won't see me in december i won't be here okay okay we'll be paying my items

[01:44:24] but um this item does take that 60 day review so january would be the earliest whatever your timeline is the next meeting after december wonderful thank you we'll miss you in december okay thank you um does the board need a brief break okay great then we will jump right in to our presentation and written reports were on item h the state special education special education advisory committee annual report thank you so much president ashton board members thank you for taking the time to review the annual report of the state special education advisory committee or

[01:45:00] seac for the 2025-2026 year superintendent conway requested that i take a moment to remind the board of the important role that the state seac plays in ensuring that the needs of students with disabilities across the commonwealth are recognized communicated and addressed the committee exists as required by the federal individuals with disabilities education act idea and the virginia state regulations for special education which call for every state to maintain an advisory panel that is focused specifically on identifying unmet needs for children with disabilities membership must include a wide range of perspectives such as parents

[01:45:37] individuals with disabilities, educators, agency representatives, and community partners. This structure ensures that the committee reflects the lived experience of those directly impacted by special education services. The SEAC meets quarterly with their subcommittees convening at the same time during these sessions and as needed throughout the year. All meetings are open to the public and follow Virginia Board of Education requirements and laws and bylaws for advisory committees. For the SEAC, public input is a vital part of the committee's work. Each meeting includes a designated public comment period where community members may share their

[01:46:13] insights, concerns, or recommendations either in person or in writing. Each and every comment received through the public comment process is thoughtfully reviewed and followed upon, reinforcing the committee's commitment to transparency and stakeholder engagement. Throughout the year, the committee also gathers information from its members constituency reports, presentations and updates on state and federal initiatives. An important reminder is that for the state SEAC there is regional representation from across the commonwealth from parents and individuals with disabilities and so they have that time and opportunity to reflect with their local constituencies and bring that information forward and you'll see that articulated in

[01:46:51] important front of you. Based on the full body of the information review the SEAC offers several recommendations to strengthen outcomes for students with disabilities. In sharing this report the committee reaffirms its commitment to elevating the voices of families, educators, and community stakeholders. Continued engagement from both the public and agency partners helps to ensure that

Virginia's policies and practices reflect the needs of the students we serve. Through this collaborative effort, the SEAC strives to support meaningful progress in the education and well-being of all students with disabilities across the commonwealth. And on behalf of the leadership

[01:47:28] of your advisory committee i also extend the invitation they are happy to come and share any additional information to advise the state board as needed and just continue to be grateful for the support and information they receive from you all and the staff at the department thank you board members uh superintendent any comments uh thank you dr hollins um and just i've had the opportunity to attend uh seac meetings and just great appreciation uh for bringing folks together

[01:48:00] It does involve travel from different areas of the Commonwealth, but to have students, educators, families, experts, military, a broad set of technical assistance organizations all at the table, thinking about some of our students furthest from opportunity is very powerful.

[01:48:23] And I appreciate the report covering the breadth of the topics that SEAC has covered. And President Ashton, if I may, I just want to say a special thank you on behalf of the SEAC to State Superintendent Conway, who made a point to visit with the committee and spend an extensive amount of time hearing directly from them about their lived experience and is scheduled to visit them again to give them an update on the strategic plan and many of the priorities that you all are discussing as well.

[01:48:48] They are very, they're always glad to have anybody join them, but it was great to hear directly from the State Superintendent. Thank you. Dr. Bridges? Can we talk through the five recommendations of the committee and just what happens with those recommendations? There's only one where the board is specifically mentioned, and it's just to encourage VDOE to review the impact of cut scores on students with disabilities and make recommendations.

[01:49:14] So that's, you know, obviously, if the board is named, I feel like we should be ensuring there's some follow up. But the other four recommendations, too, I'm wondering if you can tell us what happens to these recommendations. And I'm sure there are already agency efforts underway responsive to them. Is that something you'd be able to highlight now?

[01:49:31] Absolutely, Dr. Bridges. One, I'm happy to respond to any specific inquiries on the initiatives and recommendations from the committee that you all have taken a specific interest in. But as you can see, each of those recommendations align with information that the committee has gathered over their year. A lot of this work, as you can imagine, carries over from multiple years.

[01:49:49] so I think for a few members on the state board you'll probably notice some consistency and some patterns of the concerns and so each and every year we plan out the meetings in advance to ensure that there's representation and presentation from state agencies from partners from community members to help support the ongoing work each of these recommendations are worked on by a subcommittee that meets at each convening of the state SEAC and so they receive that information they're able to articulate it and many of those things come to recommendations back to staff so for example you can see an increased focus on supporting transition with a focus on graduation outcomes

[01:50:25] for our meeting in december we have the virginia community college system and the state council of higher ed visiting the committee to share information on updated guidance and tools that are available to students and families as they prepare for that next step and to post high school education with

a particular focus on post high programs and the community college system in creating accommodations and modifications for students with disabilities.

[01:50:49] You can also see each of the recommendations may come with additional technical assistance and guidance that the department then takes and works on throughout the year. And that filters out to our regional networks for the training and technical assistance centers. It informs not only the work that teachers and education leadership, for example, our principal and assistant principal leadership academy, all of this information gets filtered in to update the topics for that.

[01:51:14] We also get some great recommendations for not only guidance documents, but specific topics for parent education areas. And so I think if you guys follow, I'm going to date myself, if you guys follow me on Twitter or The X, you'll see every Friday is Family Engagement Friday for the department, and we focus on resources for students and families, families and students with disabilities.

[01:51:37] And so IEP University is a course that we've developed in partnership with the Parent Education Advocacy Training Center. It is an on-demand virtual course that parents can access with their cell phones and learn more about the requirements for IEPs and how to be a strong advocate for their students.

[01:51:53] We also have a transition-focused course, a course that is focused on early identification for young children. All of the information that the committee receives and digests throughout the year help to inform many of the programs and projects that you see from staff. But also I think the key thing that they would want you to take away is the policy components and just being mindful, which I know this board has been particularly around the school performance and support framework and assessment accountability, thinking about the repercussions and impact that can have on our population of students with disabilities specifically.

[01:52:27] Do you mind if I put Superintendent Conway on the spot and ask a little more on that recommendation one where the board's encouraged to review the impact of cut scores on students with disabilities. Are you thinking, I know you're always thinking, but are you thinking forward in terms of how we'll specifically be looking at those impacts well in advance of next fall? Because that's when those cuts forward rise, or this year is when they rise, but we'll be seeing those impacts and sort of how do we pay special attention as they've asked us to do on students with disabilities. Yeah, so I would actually, I appreciate that,

[01:53:06] Dr. Bridges, I mean, I would actually go next fall is when it will appear in the school performance and support framework. We're actually thinking internally about when it will appear in the 2.2 million assessments that take place, administered this spring. So, we've already begun this work, as a reminder, after we rolled out the SOL results for the prior year,

[01:53:31] We then shared with divisions, you know, modeling what it would look like if they took last spring's results and the incremental year one higher proficiency levels were applied for below basic, basic approaching proficient and advanced so that, again, divisions had at their fingertips some of that data.

[01:53:59] As we have rolled out and wrapped up the SPSF results for this year, we are now pivoting as an agency, not only focused on improvement, as you heard yesterday, but thinking about how to support the field over the course of the next six months.

[01:54:17] In fact, as Dr. Brabant noted earlier this morning, spoke with the superintendents early on Monday morning about kind of what that looks like, the why of the higher expectations. And then again, no one has a crystal ball, but assuming some consistency, as we've seen in the results over time, how to begin to think about, you know, at the building level and at the student level, what this might look like and what additional supports might be needed.

[01:54:46] And it is our goal each month for the next six months to kind of support divisions to think about the kind of recommendations, like what does this mean in terms of where we're sort of seeing our students with disabilities, we're seeing our economically disadvantaged students, we're seeing English language learners, we're seeing kind of students across the board, how are you communicating with this with families, how are you preparing educators for this.

[01:55:11] So that work will be kind of, the VDOE is already reviewing, and I think the recommendations right now are around how we're supporting the field. I think as we move through this process, if it were the desire of this body, we could certainly kind of come back and say, you know, as we roll out the higher, the year one of the higher expectations, what have we learned?

[01:55:36] And could be prepared to do that late summer, early fall, if that is of interest. Thank you. Mr. Robinson. Thank you for that. I think that would be a strong interest to the board to learn about what we're learning. And I would also invite you, what a great committee, another acronym, S-S-E-A-C.

[01:55:59] And I would really love to learn, whether it's through committee recommendations or through through, you know, BDOE's, some combination about systems or schools across the Commonwealth that are making a great difference for and rising to the higher cut scores and helping students with disabilities achieve at high levels. I love that we're thinking about, I think our overall scores as a Commonwealth, you know, went in the wrong direction this

[01:56:35] year and I know that there's a lot of concern about many schools that were identified as TSI was because special education populations and so I love the focus on support and that we're thinking if we go back to yesterday's presentation about how to combine special education funding with other sources of funding to help divisions in schools really take a thoughtful approach to lifting and in addition to that increased support I think the field would benefit from increased amplification of where it's making a difference because i worry as we increase support and talk

[01:57:10] about where um students are struggling it could reinforce a narrative that that that students uh cannot rise or are not rising to this level whereas i think there are there are clearly examples across the commonwealth uh where with the right support of course they're rising to the higher standard and i would love to for this body to be able to learn from those examples and for the field and learn examples with the support of this committee. Thank you so much, Mr. Robinson.

[01:57:38] I agree. I think the field shares those concerns, and I know we were able to touch on it a bit at last month's meeting about some of the amazing work happening for this subgroup in particular, but I would love the opportunity. You know, Dr. Burnett, who's sitting in the audience today with the aspiring leaders, was actually in Richmond last week working directly with special education directors who are focused on this topic like a laser, and that is not new for them. We have been working to build their capacity over the last three to five years. And so thinking about how we continue to move that conversation forward about systems is incredibly important. On the other side, thinking about the state SEAC, who would tell you it's just as important to think

[01:58:16] about individual students and making sure that we're not creating additional burdens for them to be successful. And so you mentioned, State Superintendent Conway mentioned the focus that this is for staff. We just finished our update of a guidance to school divisions on the provision of credit accommodations, which offers flexible pathways for students to demonstrate their academic success, which I think is key to this subgroup in particular. And so I look forward to working with my colleagues, Deputy Superintendent Hyslop and Deputy Superintendent Prophet to continue that work. And as always, we stand ready to be an example for that for neurotypical students as well. I think that's a valuable conversation and a tool that we have to support

[01:58:54] our students and their families during what can be a challenging time, but an exciting time for the Commonwealth. Thank you. Just a couple of thoughts. One, very much appreciate the report. Oh, no, no, go ahead. I'm always a closer. On this issue, one of the identifying factors coming in from the committee is the persistent shortages of special educators, paraprofessional speech language personnel. I case those in the turnover that is impacting IEP implementation. So could

[01:59:31] the board from time to time get um interim reports on then where we stand with the teacher personnel um in this area and what the turnover is looking like and you know what we've done to increase the hiring of professionals because i mean obviously you know before we can even look at what the progress is okay basically we need to make sure that there's adequate funding directed to the number of people that need to be in the classrooms and that they're some of the most highly

[02:00:07] trained people. I think it would be important for the board to know consistently where we are, the hiring professionals, where those gaps are in relationship to schools so that we can measure the performance in terms of the targeted support we're talking about, especially as it related to the number of schools that appear to be to be having difficulty and are now being rated because of students with disabilities. Thank you so much for that comment, Ms. McPherson. I know State

[02:00:41] Superintendent Conway alluded to recruitment and retention and staff preparation is a factor that we're examining quite closely. I've also been waiting all month to do this. I would love for you all to take an annual look at the annual report update we provided to the Virginia General assembly every december 1st for the last three years on special education teacher retention and recruitment it's a valuable resource for this conversation that has a lot of updated data as well as some of the initiatives that the department has undertaken and the results of those initiatives and so we would be happy to respond to any future requests to help articulate

[02:01:16] that but there is a lot of robust information out there this is a problem for every state in the nation um selfishly i think virginia is doing a better job by programs like the aspiring leaders to help address it um but definitely a critical area of issue for us to focus on i appreciate that superintendent come absolutely and and uh i i should note as as dr hollins did that it's not the only report that went to the general assembly we have a multitude of reports that are due september 1st october 1st november 1st and december 1st and so i can work with uh chief

[02:01:51] Coy and our director Chapman to make sure that you all have here the reports that have gone over if we're not required to kind of send them through you um where they come through you as we did in August we make sure to brief you but we can also send you those um and then you can see what the topic is and if it's of interest you can have that because Dr. Hollins is correct we provide that annual update on the on the sort of persistent shortages um and that it is it is more pronounced in special education and i

recognize that the department has to struggle with both you know staff and the time and the allocation the resource even internally so i'd like to recommend that we

[02:02:30] you know look at additional assistance that may be needed internally from an administrative standpoint to help out to get us focused and you know you guys are doing a great job but at the same time i just want to make sure you have enough resources internally to help us deal with this particular issue yes miss mcpherson this is actually was i think a a major point of our conversation yesterday as we heard from uh secretary smith we heard from um superintendent

[02:03:04] conway in terms of the strategic plan um what i'd like to also um emphasize what i heard in whether it is when the in the vision the mission and the values was a real focus throughout around how do we serve our students who have the highest unmet needs whether it was because of social economic factors or because of special education needs and i think there there will there was a real infusion of that and it is helpful to to receive this report and i would love to see your December report. I'll go back through it myself. I think what's what's on my mind, though, is what

[02:03:43] what I got from this report, and I would want us to just double down, is just there is a tremendous need for over communication and for more training. So I love the IEP University. I just think we have to share more of those resources consistently so that the field and the board knows that those resources exist um i think the what what it as a again former special ed teacher what what often gets mixed up is the compliance in the program and we need to make sure that we are a hundred percent

[02:04:20] in compliance which we spend a lot of time on but then um since we have our special ed leaders in the room, the programming is where we sometimes get -- it gets lost. And the reality is, the program is just good teaching. And I would not be remiss, my mentor on special education, who was a dean of William & Mary School of Education, Dean McLaughlin, she actually passed away this month. And I'm sitting here thinking, she just is sending this message to me right now, which says, good teaching is good teaching and we are not going to be the leader in the nation um if we

[02:05:01] leave this all to just the special education team or teachers this is actually everyone's collective challenge to solve and so why i am incredibly grateful for your leadership we do need everyone to come together and what i would say i i experience people are very afraid of this issue um there's a lot more fear and i think with more knowledge that we are going to be able to really um tackle the issue and that is with good communication good tools and good resources so i want to again applaud you for your leadership thank you for this report and just say that that

[02:05:39] this is everyone's challenge and opportunity it's not a division it's not a department it's not even a one teacher it's how do we make sure all of our teachers and all of our leaders have the knowledge around the compliance around the programming at the end of the day it's good tier one teaching good tier two teaching high quality instructional materials high quality standards with the additional supports and resources thank you um absolutely and i think that one of the things we talked about miss mcpherson in terms of like your very point around resources is for uh deputy

[02:06:18] superintendent high slop has been working very closely with deputy superintendent hollands as well as deputy superintendent prophet around a network to support improvement for the schools that were identified as tsi and really kind of making sure that it is instruction improvement and uh sort of thinking about special education and when you look at kind of the recommendation for and how do we

support that we were able to use some carryover funding to get that off um and and and implemented this year but i think there will be additional resources to kind of make

[02:06:54] sure just as as president ashton noted that it is around the effective use of that of that curriculum and that effective instruction with all students um and that uh you know and how do we make sure at our our schools that are otherwise you know performing well that every student has access to that and that is it takes both general education and special education educators teachers and leaders thank you and with that we appreciate the report and look forward to getting more thank you

[02:07:29] next up is item i the written report annual report on the needs and conditions of public schools in virginia anybody here want to talk about needs nobody's here nobody's back there okay then we will take a oh they're here oh sorry okay great you um is there you want to please i'm happy to speak to this item um what you will find here is a framework for the report for the boards which

[02:08:03] is required annually we anticipate bringing you the full draft of that report in december but wanted to share the framework so that you could see what we are working on and make sure that anything you want covered is captured in that so it will be back for your final review and approval at the December meeting great uh Dr. Bridges I have questions about what happens to this report I know it goes it gets posted on the website are there any other specific um dissemination channels that that occur that's a great question uh I don't know offhand but I can double check for

[02:08:41] you whether or not it also gets submitted to the General Assembly and it does okay perfect okay it does so it would be posted publicly there for anyone to find on their website as well and then a follow-up on uh thank you that was a helpful answer to that question and then just thinking about if you can't get a sense of a theme in my comments and questions for folks i'm big on alignment and making things visible to everybody so that they're really easily accessible and understandable to the public so we're all working together and what i find interesting as a board

[02:09:16] member i find it confusing and this is not a criticism of agency i'm speaking to the board now we have a comprehensive plan seven priorities if you look on the website right now you see three priorities that actually expired in 2023 and then we have this annual report with the organization that you have here we have and then we have a new vdoe strategic plan with four priorities i see that this outline um seems to be an effort to align with the video strategic plan and i'd like to encourage even further alignment like let's be consistent as consistent as we can and

[02:09:54] how we it's not changing the content it's just can we keep organizing things in a way that aligns with the very important and very public engagement driven process you just went through on on bdoe strategic planning that that works yep and you're correct that was loosely how we organized it recognizing it is also your report but can certainly look at it through that lens as well i'll note that this report really reflects um and this the statute requires that it's a report on the needs and conditions of our public schools and may also then serve as a a key component of

[02:10:30] your comprehensive plan work in 2027. absolutely i'm hoping that you know it'll be a driver for that but i do hope that after this report is published maybe we can at least get some comp you know something on the website that yes it shows it in alignment with the the board's priorities we can absolutely do that thank you so much thank you dr bridges superintendent conway no no no no no um dr bridges i appreciate your comment there there's there's this kind of reminds me of our last board meeting like we hear from the legislature we hear from staff we have from the board it's

[02:11:06] like how do we communicate alignment and there is tremendous alignment but we also have to you know pay attention to the law and we're kind of constantly cleaning up so i do appreciate um your comments as well as the staff efforts to really try to communicate the alignment with the clear focus on how are we going to be again i love to leave the nation as the secretary left us with yesterday so though we have to define that anyway um mr chadman are you here as a support to this or do you have something else to say no okay great um board members are

[02:11:40] were there any other questions around item I? Okay, thank you for your presentations. That is, I think all the reports we have officially today. I'll leave final comments or remarks from Superintendent Conway.

[02:12:01] - Well, thank you all. Thank you to Acela leaders for attending and seeing the breadth of items this body will cover we are really deeply appreciate the feedback on the strategic plan yesterday and we'll make sure that we continue to solicit any feedback that may come from this body as we look to finalize that and put that out in november in align with the desires of this body

[02:12:38] the governor and the secretary of education i think as as miss mcpherson noted is the the time of year in which you do your wish list whether that's for santa um whomever you may worship or the general assembly um but really thinking through what is it that we want to accomplish on behalf of virginia's children birth to five k-12 students so that they enter school ready and graduate school ready for success and understanding kind of where you want to go knowing how deeply this body cares about higher expectations that are nationally competitive

[02:13:17] then helps us prepare for seeking the necessary resources that all of our partners from our early childhood providers to our 131 school divisions and their boards their leaderships to our 1800 schools and their site level leaders as well as the 90 000 educators across the commonwealth get what they need to be successful in executing against those very high aspirations for our students so with that i just thank you for today and yesterday and look forward to seeing you very early in december thanks superintendent conway with that um no better words have been said i

[02:13:56] don't have anything else to say um thank you for those in attendance can i have a motion to adjourn is there a second second all in favor signify by saying aye aye okay we are adjourned thank you

